

THE EMPEROR WHO WOULD NOT KNEEL

Chapter 10 — “No Kings in the Ash”

Format: Traditional right-to-left manga script. Read panels right-to-left, top-to-bottom.

Black-and-white. Heavy ink shadow, cinematic negative space, screentone ash.

Approx. 26 pages.

PAGE 1

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (wide, full-width top — continuing from Ch.9)

The thirty ECHO WARRIORS stand in formation, fists over their chests, blue fire burning in their translucent frames. The ROMAN CENTURION at the front, gladius planted in the ground, waiting for EGRIS's answer.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (narrow, center)

The camp behind Egris — forty-three souls, watching. Terrified. Waiting to see if he will save them or doom them.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

Close on EGRIS's face. Calm. Decided.

No dialogue.

PAGE 2

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS steps forward — alone, leaving SURO and BORCHU behind. He walks toward the line of warriors.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

The CENTURION's pale eyes track him.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

EGRIS stops three paces from the Roman.

No dialogue.

Panel 4

Then he speaks, loud enough for the camp to hear.

EGRIS: “No.”

PAGE 3

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (wide, heavy silence)

The word lands like a stone in deep water.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

The CENTURION does not move. Does not lower his fist. Waiting for more.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

EGRIS: "I will not lead you. I will not command you. I will not become what you are asking me to be."

PAGE 4

Panels: 4

Panel 1

Behind him, the camp STIRS. Murmurs. Fear spreading.

WOMAN (off-panel): "What is he doing—"

Panel 2

BORCHU, grim, cutting her off.

BORCHU: "What he always does."

Panel 3

The CENTURION finally moves — pulling his gladius from the ground.

SFX: shnk

Panel 4

The other twenty-nine warriors draw their weapons in perfect unison.

SFX (layered): SHNNNG

PAGE 5

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top — the warriors advance)

The Echo line moves forward as one body. Not running. MARCHING. Disciplined. Unstoppable.

SFX: thd thd thd thd

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

EGRIS does not step back. He plants his cracked spear in the ground and STANDS.

No dialogue.

PAGE 6

Panels: 3

Panel 1

SURO's voice, calm from behind.

SURO: "Egris. You cannot fight thirty warriors alone."

Panel 2

EGRIS, not turning.

EGRIS: "I am not fighting them."

Panel 3

SURO: "Then what are you doing?"

PAGE 7**Panels: 2****Panel 1**

EGRIS: "I am refusing them."

Panel 2 (wide, bottom — the Centurion STOPS, five paces from Egris)

The entire line halts. Perfect synchronization.

No dialogue.

PAGE 8**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

The CENTURION stares at Egris. His translucent face is hard to read, but something shifts — confusion, perhaps. Or recognition.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

EGRIS speaks again, quieter now, for the Centurion alone.

EGRIS: "You were soldiers once. You followed orders. You died following them."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "And when death came, you kept following. Because it was all you knew how to do."

Panel 4

The CENTURION's grip on his gladius tightens.

No dialogue.

PAGE 9**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

EGRIS: "Someone sent you here. Told you to find me. Told you to offer me an army or destroy me if I refused."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "But they did not ask you what you wanted."

Panel 3

The CENTURION's blue fire FLICKERS — just for a moment.

No dialogue.

PAGE 10**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

EGRIS: "You are dead. The wars you fought are over. The emperors you served are dust."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "You do not owe anyone obedience anymore."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "Not me. Not whoever sent you here. Not even the memory of what you were."

Panel 4

For the first time, the CENTURION lowers his sword — not to strike, but to his side. Uncertain.

No dialogue.

PAGE 11**Panels: 2****Panel 1** (large, top)

Behind the Centurion, the other warriors BEGIN TO WAVER. Their formation loosens. A few lower their weapons. The blue fire in their chests flickers like candles in wind.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

One warrior — a SAMURAI with a broken helmet — steps OUT of formation. Then another. Then three more.

No dialogue.

PAGE 12**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

The CENTURION looks back at his fragmenting line. Then forward at Egris.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

He opens his mouth — no sound comes, but the intention is clear. A question: What do we do now?

No dialogue.

Panel 3

EGRIS: "Whatever you choose."

PAGE 13

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — the warriors dissolve)

The Echo warriors BEGIN TO FADE. Not violently. Peacefully. The blue fire dims. Their translucent forms lose definition. One by one, they release whatever command or duty held them together and simply... LET GO.

The Centurion is the last to fade, his eyes on Egris until the final moment.

SFX (soft, layered): ...fwsss...

PAGE 14

Panels: 3 (silent page)

Panel 1 (wide)

The camp stares at the empty space where thirty warriors stood moments before. Only ash and pale mist remain.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

EGRIS picks up his spear from the ground.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

He turns and walks back toward the camp.

No dialogue.

PAGE 15

Panels: 4

Panel 1

The souls part to let him through. No one speaks. They watch him with something new in their eyes — not fear, not worship. Something harder to name.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

The WOMAN IN RED steps forward, still holding the boy.

WOMAN: "You could have led them. Had an army. Been safe."

Panel 3

EGRIS stops, not looking at her.

No dialogue.

Panel 4

EGRIS: "We would not have been safe. We would have been owned."

PAGE 16**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

WOMAN: "And now? What are we now?"

Panel 2

EGRIS finally looks at her.
No dialogue.

Panel 3

EGRIS: "Alive. And still choosing."

PAGE 17**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

BORCHU approaches, gripping his broken weapon.
BORCHU: "That is the third time you have refused power, Egris."

Panel 2

BORCHU: "Heaven. Hell. And now an army of the dead. Three offers. Three refusals."

Panel 3

BORCHU: "How many more times will you be given the choice before someone stops asking?"

Panel 4

EGRIS: "I do not know."

PAGE 18**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

SURO, from the edge of the group.
SURO: "They will not stop. The offers will keep coming."

Panel 2

SURO: "Because you are the only one in the Wastes who has refused all of them."

Panel 3

SURO: "That makes you dangerous. To everyone."

PAGE 19

Panels: 3

Panel 1

ARGHUN steps forward, ink-stained fingers clutching his satchel.

ARGHUN: "I wrote it all down. The warriors. The refusal. The way they faded."

Panel 2

ARGHUN: "But I do not understand what you did, Egris. You gave them nothing. No command. No purpose. How did that defeat them?"

Panel 3

EGRIS: "I did not defeat them. I freed them."

PAGE 20

Panels: 4

Panel 1

ARGHUN: "From what?"

Panel 2

EGRIS: "From being used."

Panel 3

The scribe stares at him, then begins writing again — faster now, as if trying to capture something before it escapes.

No dialogue.

Panel 4

The camp slowly returns to its routines. The woman leads the boy back to their shelter. Borchu resumes his watch. But the air has changed. Something has shifted.

No dialogue.

PAGE 21

Panels: 3

Panel 1

SURO approaches EGRIS, speaking low.

SURO: "You know this cannot last."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "I know."

Panel 3

SURO: "Whoever sent those warriors will send something worse."

PAGE 22

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS: "Let them."

Panel 2

SURO tilts his blindfolded head.

SURO: "You sound like a man preparing for war."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "No. I sound like a man who has stopped running from it."

Panel 4

SURO: "There is a difference?"

PAGE 23

Panels: 2

Panel 1

EGRIS: "Yes. One is surrender. The other is choosing your ground."

Panel 2

SURO's mouth curves — not quite a smile, but close.

SURO: "Then we will see if your ground holds."

PAGE 24

Panels: 3 (atmospheric closing)

Panel 1 (wide)

Night falls (the Wastes' version). The camp settles. Fires burn cold. Souls whisper to one another.
No dialogue.

Panel 2

EGRIS sits alone at the camp's edge, spear across his knees, watching the horizon.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

Close on his left hand — the Reaper's Mark has grown again, black veins reaching past his wrist now, creeping toward his forearm.

No dialogue.

PAGE 25

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top — distant, unseen)

Far beyond the camp, in the deepest parts of the Wastes, something STIRS. We do not see it clearly —

only a suggestion of movement in the dark. Something vast. Something patient.
No dialogue.

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

It has been watching. And now it has decided.
No dialogue.

PAGE 26

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — closing image)

Wide shot from above: the camp, small and fragile against the endless Wastes. EGRIS at its edge, a lone figure keeping watch. The pale sky pressing down. The broken ruins stretching in all directions.

In the far distance, barely visible, a NEW SHAPE on the horizon — larger than the Echo warriors. Darker. Moving toward them.

NARRATION (box, lower corner): Three refusals. Three warnings. And now, something that would not ask.

— END OF CHAPTER 10 —

SCRIPT NOTES (for artist / letterer)

- **Reading direction:** Right-to-left. Panel 1 sits at top-right of every page.
- **This chapter is the philosophical core of the arc.** Egris defeats the Echo warriors not through violence but by freeing them from their compulsion to serve. Show this visually — the warriors don't collapse, they RELEASE. Peaceful dissolution.
- **Page 13 splash (the warriors fade)** — this must feel like a release, not a death. Use soft screentone transitions, dissolving linework. The Centurion's eyes on Egris to the last moment.
- **The Reaper's Mark (Page 24)** — show it has grown significantly. It is past his wrist now, creeping up his forearm. Visual reminder: every refusal has a cost.
- **Page 25-26 (the new threat)** — keep it VAGUE. Just a shadow, a shape, movement in the dark. Do NOT reveal it fully. Save that for Ch.11.
- **Tone:** This chapter is a victory, but a hollow one. Egris won without fighting, but he knows something worse is coming. The camp is safer but more vulnerable. The refusals are adding up.